

of the National University of Educational Planning and Administration, who has been working with Sibal on the draft since 2005, points out, an act cannot be crafted to resolve all current and future problems. Not all states are equal. Some, such as Uttarakhand will have to spend Rs 1,300 crore over the next five years while the entire North-east, excluding Assam, will have to fork out only Rs 3,600 crore. Others such as West Bengal, which has an annual education budget of Rs 1,350 crore and will have

educationist Anil Sadgopal fears? Will there be an intersection of the existing National Commission for Protection of Child Rights with the soon-to-be-formed National Advisory Council, one of which monitors the progress of the Act while the other advises the Centre on its implementation? How will the 25 per cent quota for the disadvantaged in private schools be implemented? The Government will reimburse the tuition fees but what about other expenses? It's not something that bothers evangelists like educationist Anita

Then individual states will throw up sticky issues that will have to be resolved. In Kerala, for instance, which has to spend only Rs 1,600 crore over five years, Class V has to be moved from upper primary to lower primary, and Class VIII has to be shifted from high school to upper primary, triggering a fear over the future of 20,000 teachers. The state Government fears that the new Act will also render 6,000 headmasters jobless because it does not allow the post in schools with a total strength of less than 150. Then in Gujarat, where Class VII is the upper limit for primary schools, now Class VIII will have to be added under the RTE Act. The Gujarat Government will have to bring in new legislation to effect this and recruit 60,000 new teachers in the next three years. Governments such as Haryana and Uttar Pradesh will also have to handle the problem of recognition to schools with every school being required to give self-declaration forms within three months. No school will now be able to function without a certificate of recognition from the appropriate authority.

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“ This is a standard-setting law. It can't answer all the questions that will arise from its implementation. But it must not be delayed. ”

R. GOVINDA
Vice-Chancellor, NUEPA

“ How will children admitted to private schools under the 25 per cent quota afford the quality of life of their peers? ”

PV. INDIRESAN
Former Director, IIT Madras



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to spend Rs 16,000 crore over five years, are already complaining. The questions will be addressed as they arise. For instance, what happens to the SSA? It will function as a vehicle for financial transfer to states even as a committee has already examined its role post the RTE Act. What happens to the NGOs which worked in the alternative education system? They will have to learn to engage with the formal education system. How will out-of-school children fit into the system? There will be a committee to examine the training they require to fit in.

Will there be a rush to appoint temporary, untrained and para-teachers to fulfill the conditions of the Act, as ed-

Rampal. “We didn't strengthen the public system so now we have to allow sharing of common space so children of mixed backgrounds can grow together,” she says. In any case, 93 per cent of children study in government schools and only 7 per cent in private schools. But it is an important and vocal constituency and it needs to be addressed quickly. As G.S. Sharma, president of the Karnataka Unaided Schools Management Association, which represents 1,500 schools with 25 lakh students across the state, says, “The Government has not issued any rules and regulations for the scheme, nor communicated the details to us so far.” Such doubts must not escalate.

The RTE Act will have to be modified but then society itself is in the throes of change. Demographic trends suggest that demand from schools will decline while economic growth indicates that more resources will be available to governments. Perhaps the Act may even end up resolving some of the thornier issues it avoided this time—ranging from attaching teachers to schools to the categorising of Kendriya Vidyalayas and Navodaya Vidyalayas as special schools. And perhaps the RTE Act, along with the National Food Security bill, the National Rural Employment Guarantee Act and a proposed Right to Health bill, will help in ushering a grand new social vision that the UPA hopes will translate into votes in ballot boxes. Earlier schemes such as the National Literacy Mission and the SSA created a groundswell for education as the one-stop hope. Now the RTE has to make that a reality.

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